reimagine a new Hindu identity; the Krishna messaging in the Northeast is a subtle cultural variation.

Some observers dismissed the harnessing of the Krishna–Rukmini legend as make-believe.[4] This critique, however, misses the point of this process of acculturation. From the 1950s, several academic experts on Arunachal's tribal cultures have documented the belief of the Idus—a sub-group of the Mishmi tribe—that Rukmini was one of them, and that they developed an ethnic identity around this.[5] One account of the tribe noted in 1958 that there are 'archaeological relics in Bishmaknagar in Lohit Frontier, which are said to mark the capital of King Bishmak, whose daughter Rukmini was carried away by Lord Krishna himself'.[6] The Idu Mishmis have spring love songs around the Krishna–Rukmini tale, as well as Rukmini Haran (kidnapping) dances and plays.[7] As P.N. Luthra explained in the *Economic and Political Weekly* in 1971, the Idus also call themselves 'Chulikata' (hair-cut) because of this legend: 'Rukmini, according to Idus, was carried away by Lord Krishna, which infuriated them and led to conflict between the two. The Idus admit that they came off worse and, to symbolise the humiliation of their defeat, they decided to partly cut off their hair. This earned them the name "Chulikata", a descriptive term whose origin was only recently unveiled when Bhishmaknagar fort was unearthed 18 miles from Roing in Lohit District. As to the authenticity of the legend, mythologists and historians will, no doubt, have a good deal to say.'[8]

In 1968, when figurines of Hindu yakshas, yakshinis and gods from the pantheon were unearthed in Bishmaknagar, the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA) authorised an officer with the designation of Director of Research (History) to undertake further excavations in the area. These archaeological remains, on the river Kundil near Sadiya, are part of a wider network of ancient Hindu ruins and associated legends in the area including a Parshuram Kund in Lohit district and Malinithan, a grove said to have been tended by Shiva's consort, Parvati, where Krishna and Rukmini rested on their way back to Dwarka.

The archaeological evidence shows without doubt that classical Hindu legends, influence and culture penetrated the region in ancient